there's a feeling, say insiders, that his loyalties are "no longer unimpeachable". But the former two-term CM did deliver, as the Congress wrested five of the 10 Lok Sabha seats from the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the recent general election. A big factor was the mobilisation of the Jat vote behind him. Still, the party has refrained from anointing Hooda—the leader of the Opposition since 2019—as its chief ministerial candidate.

Selja's loyalists argue that her face can help the Congress consolidate Dalit votes not just in Haryana but also in neighbouring Punjab, Rajasthan, western Uttar Pradesh and Delhi. Something similar to what the party had attempted with Charanjit Singh Channi's surprise appointment as Punjab CM just three years ago. That experiment may have failed, but giving Haryana its first Dalit CM could well be a game-changer. It will also fit well with Rahul Gandhi's aggressive stance on reservations and caste census, say insiders. The converse is equally true: estranging the Jats, who have only recently shed their fondness for the BJP, would affect the same political map. Even so, Selja's presence is keeping the Hooda camp on tenterhooks. Recently, talking to media, she exuded confidence about a Congress win and said the high command will decide the CM, who could be a Dalit too.

The Congress, of course, wants both: its ambition is to create an umbrella coalition of Jats, Dalits and Muslims in Haryana. This strategy aims to leverage Hooda's influence among the Jats, estimated to account for about a fourth of the state's electorate, while simultaneously using Selja to tap the Dalit vote, a sizeable 20 per cent. The party hopes this combination, along with traditional Muslim support, could provide a winning formula in the upcoming election. That's easier said than done, though. While Jats and Muslims are likely to be with the Congress, the Dalit vote is less certain. They may have backed the Congress in the general election, especially owing to the Opposition bloc's narrative about the Constitution being 'under threat', but this support could be less durable. What complicates the scenario are two other alliances: besides that of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) with the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD), Bhim Army chief Chandrashekhar's Aazad Samaj Party (ASP), too, has chosen to enter the fray as a partner of the Jannayak Janta Party (JJP). The prospect of this demographic being fragmented makes Selja's role all the more crucial. The central leadership fears that aggressively backing Hooda could lead to counter-polarisation among other communities, say insiders.

That said, the Congress hopes to make headway, riding on a decade-long anti-incumbency sentiment against the BJP government. The inability of the Chautalas-led INLD and JJP to rise as viable alternatives has only added to its confidence. So much so that the Congress ended its alliance with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) even after the two secured a combined vote share of 47.6 per cent in the Lok Sabha election, higher than the BJP's 46.1 per cent. A split in these votes could play a spoiler in close contests, especially in north and central Haryana. Sources say Rahul Gandhi had in fact tossed around the idea of bringing both AAP and the Samajwadi Party—two key Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance



X/@KUMARI_SELJA

THE DALIT FACE
Kumari Selja during an election rally in Jagadhri, Aug. 31

POLL POSITION

- **Bhupinder Singh Hooda, 76, faces competition for Haryana CM candidacy from Kumari Selja, 61**
- **The Congress aims to create a Jat-Dalit-Muslim coalition, with Hooda's Jat influence and Selja's Dalit background**
- **The party hopes to capitalise on anti-BJP sentiment, but internal struggles posed a challenge even in finalising candidates**